

SnowyKim California HR Information Access and Confidentiality Policy

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Policy Owner: Human Resources

Approved By: Director of Human Resources

Applies To: Employees assigned to SnowyKim's San Francisco, California office

Document Classification: Internal—Confidential

Policy ID: HR-CA-PRIV-001

1. Purpose

SnowyKim maintains employment-related information to administer payroll, benefits, performance management, workplace accommodations, leave, safety, security, and other legitimate business functions.

This policy establishes:

- Which parties may access different categories of HR information
- The conditions under which access is permitted
- How confidential information must be stored and disclosed
- Employee rights to request access to certain records
- Requirements for medical and accommodation information
- Procedures for responding to legal or government requests
- Responsibilities for preventing unauthorized access or disclosure

Access to HR information must be based on a legitimate business need. Seniority, job title, technical access, or personal familiarity with an employee does not independently create a right to view that employee's records.

2. Scope

This policy applies to:

- Regular employees
- Temporary employees
- Managers
- Executives
- Human Resources personnel
- Payroll and Finance personnel
- Benefits administrators

- Information Technology personnel
- Contractors with approved system access
- Third-party service providers processing employee information

It applies to information maintained in:

- HR information systems
 - Payroll systems
 - Benefits platforms
 - Performance-management systems
 - Leave-management systems
 - Email
 - Shared drives
 - Paper files
 - Case-management tools
 - Security systems
 - Approved company applications
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3. Governing Principles

3.1 Minimum Necessary Access

Each person may access only the information reasonably necessary to complete an authorized job responsibility.

3.2 Legitimate Business Purpose

Access must relate to an assigned business activity, such as:

- Processing payroll
- Administering benefits
- Reviewing a direct report's performance
- Managing an approved leave
- Responding to a legal obligation
- Investigating a reported workplace concern
- Maintaining an HR system
- Completing an authorized audit

Curiosity, personal interest, workplace gossip, or informal requests are not legitimate business purposes.

3.3 Separation of Duties

Technical system access does not automatically grant permission to read HR content.

For example, an IT administrator may maintain a database, restore backups, or investigate application errors without having general permission to view compensation, medical, performance, or employee-relations records.

3.4 Deny by Default

When authority is unclear, access must not be granted until Human Resources or the designated data owner confirms the request.

3.5 Individual Accountability

Employees must use their own account credentials. Shared accounts are prohibited unless specifically approved for a technical service.

Access activity may be logged and audited.

4. Information Classification

4.1 General Internal HR Information

Examples include:

- Employee handbook
- General benefits guide
- Holiday calendar
- General leave procedures
- Expense-reimbursement procedures
- Office policies
- Training materials

This information may generally be accessed by all active employees.

4.2 Employee Directory Information

Examples include:

- Employee name
- Company email address
- Job title
- Department
- Manager
- Work location
- Company telephone number

Directory information may generally be accessed internally when needed for normal company operations.

Personal phone numbers, home addresses, personal email addresses, and emergency contacts are not ordinary directory information.

4.3 Confidential Employment Information

Examples include:

- Compensation
- Bonus information
- Equity information
- Performance reviews
- Disciplinary records
- Promotion recommendations
- Employment-status history
- Work schedules
- Attendance records
- Payroll records
- Personnel-file materials
- Manager notes used for employment decisions

Access is limited to the employee, authorized managers, and personnel with an approved HR, payroll, finance, legal, or compliance responsibility.

4.4 Restricted Personal Information

Examples include:

- Home address
- Personal telephone number
- Personal email address
- Date of birth
- Emergency contacts
- Dependent information
- Bank-account details
- Tax-withholding information
- Government identification numbers
- Immigration and work-authorization documents
- Background-check information

Access is restricted to specifically authorized personnel.

4.5 Medical and Accommodation Information

Examples include:

- Medical certifications
- Disability documentation
- Accommodation requests

- Pregnancy-related medical information
- Leave certifications
- Fitness-for-duty documentation
- Workers' compensation medical information
- Benefits claims containing medical details

Medical and accommodation records must be treated as confidential and, where practical, maintained separately from ordinary personnel records.

4.6 Highly Restricted HR Information

Examples include:

- Harassment or discrimination complaints
- Investigation interviews
- Witness statements
- Attorney communications
- Ethics reports
- Whistleblower reports
- Workplace-violence assessments
- Legal-hold materials
- Settlement discussions
- Employee-relations case notes

Access is limited to specifically assigned HR, Legal, Compliance, Security, or executive personnel.

5. Access Roles

5.1 Employees

Employees may access:

- General HR policies
- Their own basic employee profile
- Their own compensation information
- Their own payroll statements
- Their own benefits elections
- Their own leave and PTO information
- Their own completed performance reviews
- Certain records they are entitled to inspect or receive under applicable law
- Records voluntarily provided to them by Human Resources

Employees may not access:

- Another employee's compensation
- Another employee's performance records
- Another employee's benefits elections

- Medical information belonging to another person
- Investigation records
- Confidential witness statements
- Manager-only planning documents
- HR case notes
- Company-wide personnel data

An employee's authorization to view their own records does not authorize them to alter those records.

5.2 Managers

Managers may access information about current direct reports when needed to perform legitimate supervisory duties.

Permitted information may include:

- Job title and job description
- Department and reporting structure
- Work schedule
- Attendance information
- Approved or pending time away from work
- Performance goals
- Performance reviews
- Corrective-action documents in which the manager participates
- Training completion
- Compensation-planning information provided through an approved process

Managers ordinarily may not access:

- Medical diagnoses
- Medical certifications
- Detailed accommodation documentation
- Benefits claims
- Bank or tax information
- Government identification numbers
- Background-check reports
- HR investigation notes
- Witness statements
- Information about employees outside their reporting structure

When an employee receives an accommodation or protected leave, managers should generally receive only the operational information needed to implement it, such as approved restrictions, schedule changes, or leave dates.

5.3 Human Resources Staff

Authorized HR staff may access records required for their assigned responsibilities.

Access may include:

- Personnel records
- Compensation information
- Benefits enrollment
- Leave records
- Performance records
- Employee-relations materials
- Onboarding and separation records
- Work-authorization documentation
- Required reporting data

HR personnel must not access employee records for personal reasons or outside their assigned scope.

5.4 HR Administrators

Designated HR administrators may receive broader access for:

- HR system administration
- Policy administration
- Compensation administration
- Employee-relations oversight
- Compliance reporting
- Audit response
- Workforce planning
- Legal response coordination
- Access-control management

Broad access does not remove the requirement for a legitimate business purpose.

5.5 Payroll and Finance

Payroll and Finance personnel may access information required to:

- Calculate and issue wages
- Process deductions
- Administer bonuses or commissions
- Complete tax reporting
- Reconcile payroll
- Process approved reimbursements
- Support authorized financial audits

They may access:

- Employee name and ID
- Pay rate
- Hours worked
- Payroll deductions

- Bank-payment details
- Tax-withholding elections
- Approved compensation changes

They ordinarily may not access:

- Medical documentation
- Detailed performance reviews
- Investigation records
- Harassment complaints
- Accommodation narratives
- Benefits claims unrelated to deductions or payment

5.6 Information Technology

IT personnel may access systems and technical information needed to:

- Provision or remove accounts
- Maintain infrastructure
- Manage authentication
- Investigate security events
- Restore records
- Resolve technical errors
- Review system logs
- Enforce retention and access controls

IT personnel may not use technical privileges to inspect HR content unless:

- The access is necessary for an assigned technical task
- The task has been appropriately authorized
- Access is limited to the minimum necessary information
- The activity is logged where technically feasible

5.7 Executives

Executives may access:

- Aggregated workforce data
- Organizational planning information
- Approved compensation reports
- Leadership succession materials
- Records needed for a specific employment decision
- Information required for legal, financial, or governance responsibilities

Executives do not automatically receive unrestricted access to every individual personnel, medical, or investigation record.

5.8 Legal Counsel

Internal or external legal counsel may access information necessary to:

- Provide legal advice
- Respond to litigation
- Conduct or supervise investigations
- Address government inquiries
- Preserve evidence
- Review compliance
- Negotiate or document disputes

Access must be coordinated through authorized Human Resources or executive personnel.

5.9 Third-Party Vendors

Approved vendors may receive employee information only when necessary to provide contracted services.

Examples include:

- Payroll processors
- Benefits administrators
- Insurance providers
- Leave administrators
- Background-check providers
- HR-system vendors
- Records-storage providers

Before information is provided, SnowyKim should confirm that:

- The vendor has an approved business purpose
- The information is limited to what is necessary
- Appropriate confidentiality and data-protection terms apply
- Access may be terminated when services end
- Security incidents must be reported promptly

6. Access Matrix

Information category	Employee	Direct manager	HR staff	HR admin	Payroll/ Finance	IT admin	Executive
General HR policies	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Internal directory	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes

Information category	Employee	Direct manager	HR staff	HR admin	Payroll/ Finance	IT admin	Executive
Own personnel information	Yes	Own only	Yes, as assigned	Yes	Limited	Technical only	Limited
Direct-report performance	No	Yes	Yes	Yes	No	No	Limited
Direct-report compensation	No	Approved processes	Limited	Yes	Yes	No	Limited
Company-wide compensation	No	No	Limited	Yes	Yes	No	Approved reports
Payroll records	Own only	Limited	Limited	Yes	Yes	Technical only	Aggregate or approved
Benefits enrollment	Own only	No	Yes, as assigned	Yes	Deduction data only	Technical only	Aggregate only
Medical documentation	Own submissions	Restrictions only	Assigned cases	Yes	No	Technical only	No
Accommodation records	Own case	Implementation details only	Assigned cases	Yes	No	Technical only	No
Investigation records	No	Limited, if involved	Assigned cases	Yes	No	Technical only	Limited, if assigned
Personal contact details	Own only	Limited business need	Yes, as assigned	Yes	Limited	Technical only	Limited
Tax and banking data	Own only	No	Limited	Yes	Yes	Technical only	No
System access logs	Own activity where provided	No	Limited	Limited	No	Yes	Limited
Aggregated workforce reports	No	Department-level	Yes	Yes	Yes	Technical metrics	Yes

“Technical only” means access may occur while maintaining or securing a system, but the role does not have general authorization to use or disclose the underlying HR information.

7. Personnel-Record Inspection Requests

Current and former California employees may request access to personnel records relating to their performance or to grievances concerning them, subject to applicable exclusions and procedures.

Requests should be submitted in writing to Human Resources at:

hr@snowykim-demo.com

The request should include:

- Employee name
- Employee ID, if known
- Current contact information
- Whether inspection or a copy is requested
- A reasonable description of the requested records

Human Resources will:

- Verify the requester's identity
- Determine which records are covered
- Apply legally permitted exclusions
- Coordinate inspection or copying within the required period
- Protect information belonging to other employees
- Document the response

Records that may be excluded or redacted include information protected by privilege, certain investigation materials, confidential references, records involving another person, or records otherwise excluded by law.

SnowyKim will not retaliate against an employee for making a lawful records request.

8. Payroll-Record Requests

Employees may request copies of or access to payroll records that California law requires employers to maintain or provide.

Requests should be directed to Human Resources or Payroll.

Before releasing payroll information, SnowyKim will verify the employee's identity.

Payroll information will not be disclosed to a manager, coworker, family member, or other third party merely because that person requests it.

Disclosure to an authorized representative may require written authorization or other legally sufficient documentation.

9. Medical and Accommodation Confidentiality

Medical and accommodation information must be:

- Marked or classified as confidential
- Stored separately from general personnel materials when practical
- Accessible only to authorized personnel
- Shared with managers only to the extent necessary to implement restrictions or accommodations
- Protected from informal discussion
- Transmitted through approved secure methods

A manager may be informed that an employee:

- Is approved for leave
- Has a modified schedule
- Has work restrictions
- Requires particular equipment
- Should not perform a specified task

The manager generally should not receive the employee's diagnosis or unrelated medical history.

Employees handling medical information must not disclose it to coworkers or other managers without authorization or a lawful need.

10. Investigation Records

Workplace-investigation information is restricted.

Access may be provided to:

- Assigned HR personnel
- Assigned investigators
- Legal counsel
- Compliance personnel
- Security personnel when relevant
- Decision-makers with a legitimate need
- Government agencies or courts when legally required

Managers and witnesses may receive only the information needed to participate in or respond to the investigation.

SnowyKim may be unable to guarantee absolute confidentiality because information may need to be shared to investigate, take corrective action, or satisfy legal obligations. However, information should be limited to individuals with a legitimate need to know.

Investigation participants must not retaliate against any person who reports a concern or participates in an investigation.

11. Disclosure to Government Agencies and Courts

SnowyKim may disclose HR information when required or permitted by:

- A subpoena
- A court order
- A warrant
- A government audit
- A regulatory request
- Wage or tax-reporting requirements
- Benefits-administration requirements
- Workers' compensation requirements
- A legal obligation to report or investigate conduct

Employees receiving such requests must not respond independently unless they are authorized to do so.

Requests must be promptly forwarded to Human Resources and, when appropriate, Legal Counsel.

SnowyKim may verify:

- The identity of the requesting party
- The authority supporting the request
- The scope of information requested
- Whether employee notice is required
- Whether objections, redactions, or protective measures are appropriate

Only responsive information should be disclosed.

12. Disclosure to Family Members and Personal Representatives

SnowyKim will not provide confidential employment information to an employee's family member, spouse, partner, friend, or emergency contact solely because of that relationship.

Disclosure may occur when:

- The employee provides valid written authorization
- A legally recognized representative presents sufficient authority
- Disclosure is required by law
- Disclosure is necessary during a genuine emergency
- The information is needed to administer benefits or another authorized service

The scope of disclosure must be limited to the authority provided.

13. Internal Sharing

Employees must not send confidential HR information through:

- Personal email
- Personal cloud storage
- Unapproved messaging applications
- Public or broadly accessible channels
- Unrestricted shared folders

Before sharing HR information internally, the sender must confirm:

- The recipient's identity
- The recipient's business need
- The recipient's authority
- The minimum information necessary
- The appropriateness of the communication method

Documents must not be labeled "confidential" as a substitute for applying proper access controls.

14. Printed Records

Printed confidential HR documents must:

- Be retrieved promptly from printers
- Be stored in locked locations
- Not be left in meeting rooms or common areas
- Not be taken off-site without authorization
- Be disposed of through secure shredding

Employees working remotely must prevent household members and visitors from viewing confidential records.

15. Corrections to Employee Information

Employees should notify Human Resources when their personal information changes, including:

- Legal name
- Home address
- Telephone number
- Emergency contact
- Tax-withholding information
- Beneficiary information

- Work-authorization status, when applicable

Employees who believe an HR record is inaccurate may submit a written correction request.

SnowyKim will review the request but may preserve the original record when required for historical, legal, audit, or documentation purposes. A correction, clarification, or employee statement may be added where appropriate.

16. Privacy Notices and Employee Requests

When applicable, SnowyKim will provide California employees with required notices describing the categories of personal information collected and the purposes for which that information is used.

Privacy requests must be sent to:

privacy@snowykim-demo.com

SnowyKim will:

- Verify the requester's identity
- Determine whether the request is covered by applicable law
- Apply any legal exceptions
- Search appropriate systems
- Respond within applicable time periods
- Maintain a record of the request and response

A privacy request does not necessarily require deletion of information that SnowyKim must retain for payroll, tax, legal, security, benefits, employment, or compliance purposes.

17. Security Incidents

A suspected HR-data incident must be reported immediately.

Examples include:

- Sending a personnel file to the wrong person
- Losing a laptop containing employee records
- Sharing a payroll spreadsheet through an unrestricted link
- Viewing employee records without authorization
- Discovering exposed passwords or authentication tokens
- Downloading HR records to a personal device
- Receiving a suspicious request for employee information
- Discovering malware in an HR system
- Misplacing printed medical documentation

Reports should be sent to:

- Human Resources: hr@snowykim-demo.com
- Information Security: security@snowykim-demo.com

Employees should not delete evidence, conceal the incident, or attempt an unauthorized investigation.

18. Access Reviews

Human Resources and Information Technology will periodically review:

- Active user accounts
- Assigned access roles
- Administrative privileges
- Vendor access
- Shared folders
- Departed-employee accounts
- Access logs
- Dormant accounts
- Role changes following transfers or promotions

Access must be removed or adjusted promptly when:

- Employment ends
 - A contractor's engagement ends
 - An employee changes roles
 - A manager no longer supervises an employee
 - A business need ends
 - Access was granted incorrectly
 - Security concerns arise
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19. Record Retention

HR records must be retained according to SnowyKim's approved record-retention schedule and applicable legal requirements.

Employees must not independently destroy, alter, conceal, or permanently remove HR records.

Normal deletion must stop when records are subject to:

- Litigation
- A legal hold
- An investigation
- An audit

- A government inquiry
- A pending employee dispute
- Another preservation requirement

Duplicate working copies should be deleted when no longer needed, provided the official record remains preserved.

20. Prohibited Conduct

The following conduct is prohibited:

- Accessing HR records without a business need
- Searching for friends, relatives, executives, or coworkers out of curiosity
- Sharing compensation or medical records without authorization
- Using another employee's account
- Allowing another person to use an authenticated session
- Altering access logs
- Downloading restricted records to personal devices
- Using HR information for retaliation, harassment, or personal advantage
- Disclosing investigation information to unauthorized parties
- Retaining records after access authorization ends
- Attempting to bypass technical or administrative controls

Violations may result in removal of access, corrective action, termination, contractual remedies, or legal action.

21. Non-Retaliation

SnowyKim prohibits retaliation against a person who, in good faith:

- Reports a privacy or confidentiality concern
- Reports unauthorized access
- Requests access to records
- Participates in an investigation
- Exercises an applicable privacy right
- Refuses to make an unauthorized disclosure

Knowingly making a false report may itself violate company policy, but an unsubstantiated good-faith concern is not considered a false report.

22. Questions and Escalation

Questions about access to HR records should be directed to:

Human Resources

hr@snowykim-demo.com

Privacy-related questions should be directed to:

Privacy Office

privacy@snowykim-demo.com

Security incidents should be directed to:

Information Security

security@snowykim-demo.com

When authorization is uncertain, employees must pause and request guidance before accessing or disclosing the information.

23. Policy Administration

Human Resources owns this policy and may issue supporting procedures, access matrices, forms, and retention schedules.

SnowyKim may revise this policy to reflect:

- Legal changes
- Regulatory guidance
- Security requirements
- Organizational changes
- New systems
- Audit findings
- Operational needs

Employees will be notified of material changes as appropriate.

24. Acknowledgment

Employees with access to confidential HR information may be required to acknowledge that they:

- Have read this policy
 - Understand their access limitations
 - Will use information only for authorized purposes
 - Will report suspected incidents
 - Understand that access may be monitored
 - Will return or securely dispose of records when required
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Demonstration disclaimer: SnowyKim, its employees, email addresses, systems, and policies are fictional. This policy is intended for HR chatbot and access-control testing and is not legal advice.